

CSPG4 tissue RNA in extraskeletal myxoid chondrosarcoma: an exploratory comparison across sarcoma cohorts

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Running title. Comparative CSPG4 RNA in EMC

Abstract

Background: The interpretation of CSPG4 RNA in extraskeletal myxoid chondrosarcoma (EMC) depends on the sarcoma used for comparison. We examined whether the observed differences recur across datasets.

Methods: We compared a fixed panel of 11 genes in nine EMC tumors and 45 tumors from three other sarcoma types. A second dataset contained six EMC biopsies and 17 low-grade fibromyxoid sarcomas (LGFMS). We retained the original panel rule, individual comparator results and sensitivity analyses. CHRNA6 was a separate RNA-marker control.

Results: CSPG4 RNA was higher in EMC than in LGFMS in both datasets: the probability-of-superiority score A was 1.000 in the arrays and 0.966 in the RNA-sequencing cohort, where 0.5 indicates neutral ordering. Other specified comparisons were also positive, but the comparison with dermatofibrosarcoma protuberans was not ($A=0.467$). CSPG4 alone met the original panel rule. Its primary composite was 0.895 using all years and 0.811 within sequencing years. Only four EMC patients supported the matched composite. Removing the 2019 group left two matchable EMC patients and reversed that composite to 0.433; the all-year composite remained positive at 0.833.

Conclusions: These small public cohorts support a recurring CSPG4 RNA difference against LGFMS, alongside comparator dependence and sparse matching support. They provide descriptive evidence for studies of EMC tissue, without establishing diagnostic accuracy, malignant-cell protein localization or therapeutic suitability.

Keywords

Keywords. extraskeletal myxoid chondrosarcoma; CSPG4; CHRNA6; tissue RNA; comparator sensitivity; reproducibility

Introduction

RNA measurements can identify genes worth examining further in rare tumor tissue. They cannot establish where the corresponding proteins are located, whether a treatment could reach them, or whether treatment would spare normal tissues. A tissue sample contains several cell types, so its combined, or bulk, RNA signal does not identify the cells that produced it. Results also depend on which cancer types are compared. A gene may show higher RNA levels in extraskeletal myxoid chondrosarcoma (EMC) than in one type of sarcoma, but not another.

CHRNA6 provides a useful example of what RNA evidence can establish. Dulken and colleagues identified this gene through expression-array analysis of GSE24369. They subsequently demonstrated strong, diffuse CHRNA6 RNA staining in 25 EMC cases using chromogenic in situ hybridization (CISH), an assay that shows RNA within tissue. None of the tumors resembling EMC in their comparison series met the threshold for overexpression. Limited below-threshold signal nevertheless occurred in 69 of 685 such tumors. This was an RNA tissue assay, not protein immunohistochemistry or an experiment testing whether treatment could reach a target.[1] We therefore use CHRNA6 as a previously supported RNA-marker control, not a newly discovered target. Reanalyzing the array in which it was discovered is not an independent validation of that discovery.

We asked whether RNA differences between EMC and named sarcoma types recur across datasets, with CSPG4 as the main finding from a fixed 11-gene panel. We retained results for each comparison type, also called a histology, and compared the same histology across public RNA-sequencing and expression-array cohorts. This distinguishes a repeatable comparison from an impression that a gene is uniformly high in EMC relative to sarcoma generally. It does not rank proteins as treatment targets. Normal-tissue and protein observations provide separate context for questions that the RNA comparisons cannot answer.

Methods

Cohorts and fixed panel

We used the public RNA-sequencing data released by Hofvander et al.[2] The release contains measurements for 19,116 genes in 704 patients, together with sample metadata and supplementary clinical and pathological information. RNA abundance is reported as transcripts per million (TPM). The study primarily recruited patients diagnosed and treated in Lund or Stockholm during 1988–2020; some specimens came from earlier collaborations. Gene quantification used STAR 2.7.10b/GRCh38 and RSEM 1.3.3/Ensembl 104. We retained the diagnoses in the original Table S1 and separately examined the effect of diagnoses revised using transcriptomic information.

We retained nine primary EMC specimens after applying fixed exclusions to the 13 available specimens. The excluded cases were three explicitly reported in earlier publications (104-92, 168-97 and 536-00) and one local recurrence (5081-14). We applied the same specimen policy to the comparison sarcomas: any nonblank recurrence or metastasis flag led to exclusion. These exclusions remove documented overlap with earlier studies. A blank publication reference, however, does not prove that a sample has never appeared elsewhere. Independence from all historical datasets is therefore probable rather than completely verified.

The 11-gene panel came from the research program's curated list of genes named in proposed cell-directed, stromal and peptide-HLA approaches. Here, stromal approaches concern the supporting tissue around tumor cells. Peptide-HLA approaches concern protein fragments displayed by human leukocyte antigen (HLA) molecules. The documented panel source includes corrections to its coverage of stromal targets and CSPG4; it does not claim to include all cell-surface proteins, or the entire surfaceome [3]. We froze the exact list and selection rule before inspecting target values in the new cohort [4]. This timing was prospective to our analysis of those values. It was not public preregistration or prospective specimen collection.

The fixed panel contained CD276, SSTR2, PRAME, FAP, CD248, CSPG4, MSLN, L1CAM, GPC3, ALPP and CDH17. We analyzed CHRNA6 separately. PRAME represents a proposed intracellular peptide-HLA target rather than an ordinary intact surface protein; no endogenous peptide presentation was measured. Each gene symbol had one exact row in the TPM matrix. We did not select samples or genes on the basis of their expression values.

The primary comparisons used three sarcoma types from the same cohort: myxoid liposarcoma (MLPS; n=14), low-grade fibromyxoid sarcoma (LGFMS; n=13) and synovial sarcoma (n=18). Each type received equal weight in the combined result. Myxofibrosarcoma (MFS) and dermatofibrosarcoma protuberans (DFSP) were separate context comparisons.

The second dataset, GSE24369 on platform GPL6244, provided the original expression-array measurements for 42 samples.[5] These comprised 6 EMC biopsies, 17 LGFMS, 6 MFS, 6 desmoids, 5 solitary fibrous tumors (SFT) and 2 pooled skeletal-muscle RNAs. We retained all original biopsies because their lesion stage was not established; they were not assumed to be primary lesions. The two muscle pools supplied descriptive context, not two individual healthy controls. Before inspecting target values, we selected one uniquely assigned transcript cluster per gene from the original platform annotation. We used the released robust multi-array average (RMA) log2 signals without standardizing values across genes or rounding them.

Comparison score and original panel rule

We summarized each gene's RNA levels with a pairwise comparison score, A , also called probability of superiority. For every available pair consisting of one EMC specimen and one comparator specimen, the score counts 1 when the EMC value is higher and 0.5 when the values tie. Averaging these contributions gives $A = P(\text{EMC} > \text{comparator}) + 0.5P(\text{tie})$. $A = 0.5$ means neither group tends to have higher values; $A = 0.7$ corresponds to 70% superiority after assigning half of tied pairs. Scores above 0.5 favor EMC; scores below 0.5 favor the comparator. This score is neither a fold change nor diagnostic classification accuracy established in an external test set.

We calculated the all-year (marginal) summary using all nine EMC specimens. We also compared samples sequenced in the same year as a limited check for possible differences in laboratory processing. Sequencing year is an incomplete proxy for processing conditions, not the date of specimen collection or a biological exposure. This comparison does not test whether EMC changes annually or identify a particular laboratory effect. The year-matched summary compares EMC with each sarcoma type only within exact sequencing years that contain both groups. A year remained eligible even if one group contained only one specimen, a singleton stratum. Within each histology, we weighted each supported year's score by its number of EMC specimens.

The available years differed across the comparison types. MLPS and LGFMS supported comparisons in 2019 and 2021; synovial sarcoma supported 2019 and 2020. Each matched comparison therefore used three EMC specimens. Four unique patients contributed across the three comparisons, rather than nine independent matched patients. The same two EMC patients sequenced in 2019 supplied two-thirds of the EMC weight in each matched histology comparison. Both the marginal and matched composite scores give equal weight to the three histologies. These summaries answer different questions and were not substituted for one another.

The tissue-prioritization rule required a gene to meet all three conditions. Its marginal equal-histology score had to be ≥ 0.70 . Each primary histology had to have $A > 0.50$ in both the marginal and matched comparisons. Finally, both composite scores had to remain > 0.50 after removing each EMC specimen in turn and each histology in turn. We froze the 0.70 benchmark as a tangible 20-percentage-point departure from neutral ordering. It was not chosen from the new values and is not a clinical cutoff. We also specified checks for sequencing-year removal, comparator-patient removal and revised diagnoses. Those checks qualify interpretation; they are not additional pass criteria. No rule was applied to CHRNA6. This operational rule selects a pattern of within-gene RNA comparisons; it is not a validated ranking of therapeutic candidates. A larger A for one gene than another does not establish greater absolute RNA abundance or protein abundance across genes. Failure of the rule does not exclude a gene from a different biological use.

To compare cohorts, we used the LGFMS-specific score calculated separately in each dataset. This keeps the comparison histology the same across the two measurement platforms. MFS, SFT and desmoid were separate secondary comparisons shared by both cohorts. We compared score size, direction and sensitivity to removing each biopsy in turn. We did not pool values across platforms, set another success cutoff or replace the LGFMS comparison with a different composite. We excluded GSE4303 from abundance replication because the composition of its two-color reference was unresolved.

Uncertainty and reproducibility

We used bootstrap resampling to describe uncertainty in the primary Hofvander estimates. This method repeatedly samples the observed specimens with replacement. We generated 2000 resamples (seed 20260906), separately within histology and sequencing-year groups, and shared each EMC resample across comparisons. The reported 2.5th–97.5th percentiles are pointwise intervals: they describe each estimate separately and are conditional on the groups observed in this dataset. A group with only one specimen remains fixed during resampling. The resulting interval can therefore be too narrow or have identical endpoints.

We report the underlying counts, each specimen's placement in the comparisons, and every single-patient, histology and year removal alongside the intervals. Removing a year or its last specimen can leave a comparison without support. We recalculated the weights after removal and left unsupported comparisons undefined. Removing a sequencing-year group also removes particular patients and changes which comparisons remain possible. These omissions therefore assess dependence on the observed sample groups; they do not isolate a causal effect of sequencing year or laboratory processing. We did not report P values or select a discovery set through multiple-testing procedures.

The Human Protein Atlas (HPA) supplied separate context on normal-tissue expression and protein location through its gene XML/JSON records.[6, 7] We distinguished version 25 XML entries from the current 25.1 documentation. We retained warnings about normal-tissue immunohistochemistry (IHC), an antibody-based protein stain, including uncertain reliability and absent records. We also retained disagreements about location across assay compartments and ambiguity about antibody specificity. We did not calculate a safety ratio between HPA normalized TPM (nTPM) and tumor TPM. Historical GSE28866 findings used a different quantity: 3SEQ RNA peaks on a depth-scaled, square-root-compressed scale.[8] We considered that context separately, without pooling its values or counting four EMC library records as four established independent patients.

We froze the sample and probe selection rules and the prioritization rule before inspecting new target-expression values. Source files, metadata and code are identified by fixed cryptographic hashes. An independent implementation read the original arrays, platform annotation and RNA-sequencing matrix again. It reproduced the estimates and the specimen, histology and year removal calculations. The supplement identifies the exact files and remaining limits on their provenance. The present revision gives the descriptive cross-cohort comparisons greater interpretive emphasis after review of the completed analysis. This is a change in framing, not a prospective change to the original protocol, outcomes or pass criteria; all original rule results and adverse checks remain reported.

Use of artificial intelligence. OpenAI Codex assisted with source recovery and organization, analysis-code implementation, execution, verification, and manuscript drafting. Independent implementations checked original source values and the reported arithmetic. AI assistance does not establish biological validity; responsibility for the final interpretation and released article remains with the author.

Results

CSPG4 RNA differences against specified sarcomas recurred across cohorts

The CSPG4 comparison with LGFMS agreed across cohorts. A was 1.000 in the arrays, 0.96581 in the marginal Hofvander comparison and 0.93333 in the matched Hofvander comparison. Removing each EMC or LGFMS array biopsy in turn retained A=1. Three secondary histologies shared by both datasets also had positive CSPG4 differences. Array A was 1 versus each of MFS, SFT and desmoid. The respective Hofvander marginal/matched scores were 0.85370/0.85714, 0.87879/0.62500 and 1/1. These results support consistent ordering against those particular histologies, not universal specificity.

The full panel shows why the comparator matters

CSPG4 was the only gene in the fixed panel to meet the prioritization rule. Its marginal composite score was A=0.89454, with a pointwise conditional interval of 0.86614–0.91806. Its matched score was A=0.81111 (0.75278–0.86111). The marginal scores were 0.78571 versus MLPS, 0.96581 versus LGFMS and 0.93210 versus synovial sarcoma. The corresponding matched scores were 0.66667, 0.93333 and 0.83333. CHRNA6 had A=1 across these comparisons but remained outside the 11-gene pass count. Figure 1 and Table S1 include every gene, including those with reversed or neutral differences.

PRAME and L1CAM RNA values tended to be higher in EMC than in LGFMS in both datasets, but neither met the broader rule. Other Hofvander histologies gave lower or reversed comparisons. For PRAME, marginal A was 0 versus MLPS and 0.00617 versus synovial sarcoma. L1CAM's marginal composite was 0.69931, near but below the 0.70 threshold. Its synovial comparison was also independently nonpositive: 0.43827 marginal and 0.32500 matched. L1CAM therefore failed for more than a small difference from the numerical threshold.

Several other genes gave discordant or nonpositive results. MSLN, SSTR2, GPC3 and FAP had opposite LGFMS comparison directions in GSE24369 and Hofvander. CD276, CD248 and CDH17 were below 0.5 against LGFMS in both cohorts. ALPP had positive marginal ordering against LGFMS, but its matched A was 0.5. These results prevent any interpretation based only on each gene's most favorable comparison.

Sensitivity analyses and a contrary comparator qualify the RNA comparisons

Removing individual EMC specimens or entire histologies did not reverse the CSPG4 composite. Within Hofvander, single-EMC deletion composite ranges were 0.88136–0.94035 marginal and 0.71667–0.94444 matched. Single-histology deletion ranges were 0.85891–0.94896 and 0.75000–0.88333. Removing the 2019 group removed two EMC and 19 primary comparator specimens. Seven EMC remained in the all-year comparison, but only two distinct EMC patients remained eligible for the matched comparisons. The matched composite fell to 0.43333, while the marginal value remained positive at 0.83333 (Figure 2). Thus the matched summary relies heavily on a small shared patient group. This is not a reversal caused by deleting a single EMC patient. Removing the group changes patients, comparator composition and matching support together. The conditional bootstrap does not resolve this limitation.

Using revised diagnoses gave similar composites: 0.89475 marginal and 0.81111 matched. These revised labels were partly informed by expression data, so this check is not independent confirmation.

DFSP provided a contrary comparison. CSPG4 RNA was not higher in EMC than in DFSP marginally ($A=0.46667$). The matched DFSP comparison was especially sparse, with one EMC and three DFSP specimens in 2021. DFSP was outside the primary success rule, but its contrary result remains consequential context.

Protein and normal-tissue observations limit what RNA can establish

Normal-tissue observations do not establish that CSPG4 would spare normal tissues or be accessible on EMC cells. The retrieved HPA CSPG4 record describes broad cytoplasmic protein staining in normal tissues by IHC. In contrast, its immunocytochemistry/immunofluorescence

(ICC/IF) records include membrane localization. These assays examine different compartments; their findings cannot establish EMC cell-surface density or normal sparing. Historical GSE28866 CSPG4 peak medians were broadly positive, yet a normal-colon record exceeded the lowest EMC library value. Although that dataset measures a different quantity, this overlap directly argues against treating positive group medians as separation of every individual tumor from normal tissue. Historical CHRNA6 peak signal was nonuniform. That finding neither invalidates the published RNA CISH assay nor implies that the whole transcript is absent.

Separate protein evidence also cautions against inferring a PRAME target from the RNA comparisons. Cammareri et al. assessed PRAME with antibody clone QR005 on whole sections from 350 soft-tissue tumors and mimics.[9] Their original supplementary rows 128–132 contain five EMC cases. All five were negative in both reader columns; negative meant 0% positive cells. Four had recorded fusion or rearrangement support, and one had no recorded ancillary test. PRAME expression was common in MLPS and synovial sarcoma in that study. Higher PRAME RNA ranks in EMC than in LGFMS therefore do not establish PRAME protein positivity or a therapeutic target in EMC. These protein observations come from a separate cohort and assay, not a paired RNA–protein experiment.

Discussion

The clearest observation is a recurring CSPG4 RNA difference between EMC and LGFMS in two public cohorts measured by different platforms. Several other named comparisons were positive, whereas DFSP supplied a contrary comparison. This is useful comparative evidence about EMC tissue: it identifies the settings in which the RNA contrast recurs and those in which it does not. It does not establish that CSPG4 is uniquely expressed in EMC or that it is the best treatment target.

CSPG4 is already a subject of sarcoma research. Boudin and colleagues studied its expression and clinical and immune associations across a large, heterogeneous soft-tissue sarcoma series.[10] Our contribution is narrower: the EMC comparisons presented here, together with their specimen-level support and contrary results. We do not claim discovery of CSPG4 as a sarcoma-associated gene, an exhaustive novelty assessment, or transfer of broad sarcoma prognostic findings to EMC.

The complete panel makes the comparator dependence visible. PRAME and L1CAM have positive ordering against LGFMS in both datasets, but not against all primary comparison types; several other genes change direction between datasets. CSPG4 alone meets the original operational rule, but this does not show that the remaining genes are biologically uninteresting. A tumor need not express more of a protein than another sarcoma for that protein to have a useful biological or therapeutic role. CHRNA6 reproduces a previously supported RNA-marker result and is not a new

discovery here. Its established CISH performance cannot be transferred to CSPG4 or to protein detection.

The year-matched analysis has particularly limited support. Only four unique EMC patients contribute, and deleting the 2019 group leaves two matchable patients and reverses the matched composite, while the all-year composite remains positive. This is an adverse diagnostic of dependence on a small shared sample group. It neither identifies a biological change by year nor separates processing effects from patient composition and chance. It also does not prove that the favorable all-year estimate is unbiased. The original result and its limitations are retained without treating this deletion as an independent biological finding or changing the rule after observing it.

The available cohorts remain small convenience samples. The lesion stage of the array biopsies is unknown, and removing explicitly documented old cases cannot prove the absence of all historical overlap. Sequencing year is an incomplete processing proxy: samples sequenced in the same year need not share laboratory conditions, and samples sequenced in different years need not differ. Matching on that proxy excludes five of the nine EMC patients and does not establish control of technical confounding. The present data cannot determine how much technical variation contributes to the observed RNA differences.

Bulk tissue mixes malignant and nonmalignant cells, so an RNA difference need not originate in cancer cells. EMC purity and grade were unavailable for adjustment. TPM and RMA signals have different measurement properties, even though the same rank-based score summarizes each. Normal tissues were not matched to tumors, and HPA contains incomplete or uncertain protein evidence. The two muscle pools cannot establish organ safety. We did not assess sex- or gender-specific effects, and these small cohorts do not establish generalizability across those groups.

The study therefore contributes a transparent, comparator-specific RNA account rather than a therapeutic selection procedure. It can inform tissue studies and provide explicit comparisons for subsequent datasets. Demonstrating malignant-cell localization, protein accessibility, diagnostic performance or a therapeutic window requires evidence beyond these RNA comparisons. A therapeutic window means a range in which treatment controls the tumor without unacceptable harm to normal tissues; it has not been established here.

Data code and declarations

Data availability. Original measurements and metadata are available from the Hofvander author release and Zenodo record (<https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.17866629>), GEO GSE24369/GPL6244 (<https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/geo/query/acc.cgi?acc=GSE24369>), GEO GSE28866 (<https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/geo/query/acc.cgi?acc=GSE28866>) and the archived Human Protein Atlas entries

identified in the supplement. The complete code/data supplement is publicly deposited with Research Square version 1 [4]:

<https://assets-eu.researchsquare.com/files/rs-10959636/v1/b95606f3a3799c60c8ac4434.zip>. It contains the frozen protocols, original source hashes, specimen/probe mappings, analysis code, full-panel effect tables and offline replay instructions. This revision changes presentation and documentation; it retains the same computations and archived evidence. The manuscript license does not replace source-specific attribution or reuse conditions in that archive.

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Research scope and declarations. This work reanalyzes public data and reports no newly collected participant specimens, intervention, protein experiment or clinical treatment. No new ethics approval, exemption or waiver is asserted.

CRedit authorship contribution statement. Tristan D. McRae: Project administration, Supervision. The AI-assisted implementation, execution, verification and drafting are disclosed in Methods. The author is responsible for the final interpretation and manuscript.

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Declaration of generative AI and AI-assisted technologies. OpenAI Codex assisted with source organization, code implementation, computation, verification and drafting, as described in Methods. The author takes responsibility for the article; AI assistance is not biological validation.

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Figure legends

Figure 1. Fixed-panel probability of superiority by comparator and cohort. The comparison score A describes whether EMC specimens tend to have higher RNA levels than comparator specimens. Rows include all 11 candidate genes and the separately marked CHRNA6 control. Panel A keeps the comparator type fixed at LGFMS. It shows original arrays (6 EMC, 17 LGFMS), the Hofvander marginal comparison (9 EMC, 13 LGFMS), and the Hofvander year-matched comparison (3 EMC, 12 LGFMS across 2019/2021). Panels B and C show all three primary Hofvander histologies separately, using marginal and supported-year comparisons respectively. Color and printed values encode A on 0–1 with a neutral midpoint of 0.5; there are no significance stars. Each primary matched comparison uses three EMC patients, with four unique EMC patients across the three comparisons. Scores summarize within-gene group differences; their ordering across genes does not establish relative protein abundance or therapeutic value.

Figure 2. CSPG4 specimens and sensitivity to removing sequencing-year sample groups. Panel A shows each retained primary specimen's $\log_2(1+TPM)$, grouped by EMC and the three primary comparator histologies; color denotes sequencing year. This display transformation does not enter the rank calculations. Panel B shows the matched equal-histology score after removing each year in turn, beside the full-data value and neutral 0.5 reference. Removing the 2019 sample group lowers the matched score from 0.81111 to 0.43333 and reduces its support from four unique EMC patients

to two. The marginal score remains positive at 0.83333. This sensitivity analysis measures dependence on the observed year groups; it does not identify the cause of the difference. Points describe the observed and year-removal values; they are not confidence limits. No normal-tissue or protein measurements are plotted.

Figure 1

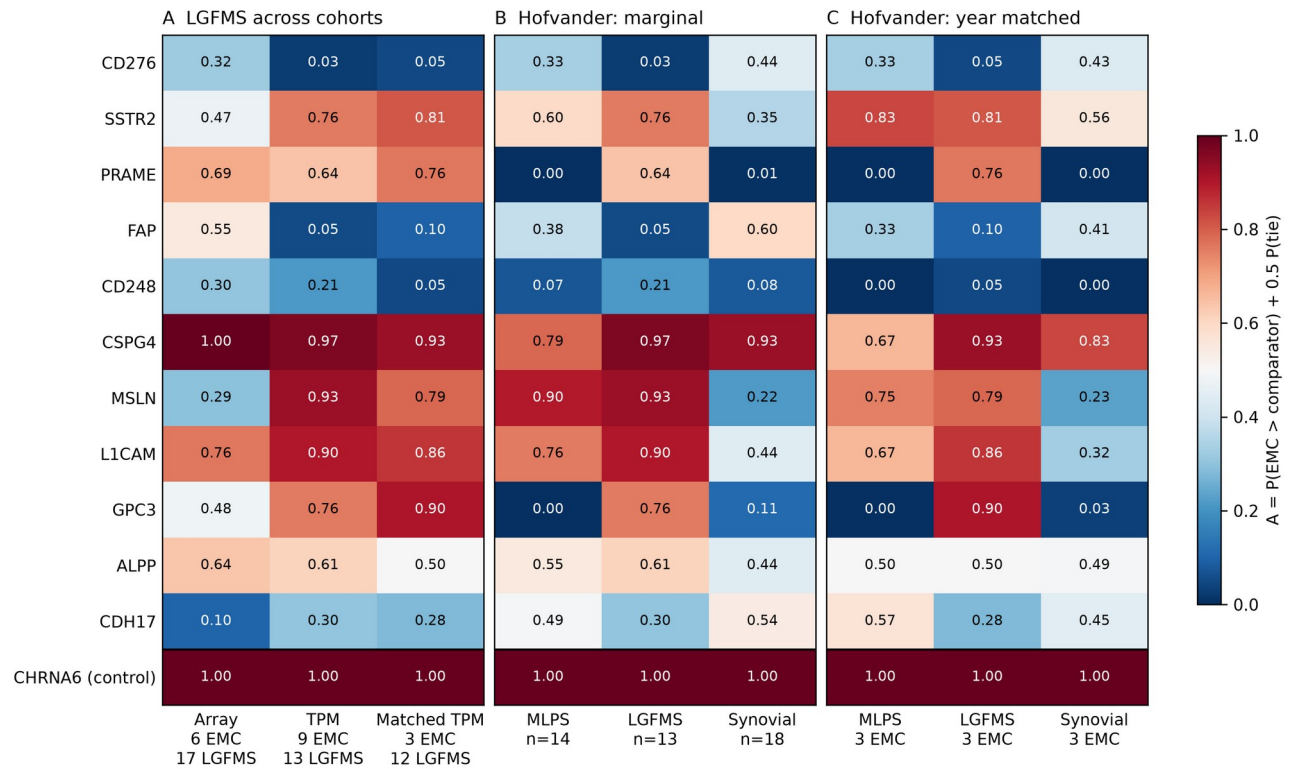


Figure 2

